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Security Council

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New York

President:	Mr. Lee Kyung Chul	(Republic of Korea)
Members:	Algeria	Mr. Yahiaoui
	China	Mr. Geng Shuang
	Denmark	Ms. Landi
	France	Mr. Bonnafont
	Greece	Mrs. Balta
	Guyana	Mrs. Rodrigues-Birkett
	Pakistan	Mr. Ahmad
	Panama	Mr. Alfaro de Alba
	Russian Federation	Mr. Nebenzia
	Sierra Leone	Mr. Totangi
	Slovenia	Mrs. Blokar Drobič
	Somalia	Mr. Abdullahi Yusuf
	United Kingdom of Great Britain and Northern Ireland	Mr. Kariuki
	United States of America	Mr. Kelley

Agenda

The situation in Afghanistan

Report of the Secretary-General on the situation in Afghanistan and its implications for international peace and security (S/2025/554)

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The meeting was called to order at 10.35 a.m.

Adoption of the agenda

The agenda was adopted.

The situation in Afghanistan

Report of the Secretary-General on the situation in Afghanistan and its implications for international peace and security (S/2025/554)

The President: In accordance with rule 37 of the Council's provisional rules of procedure, I invite the representatives of Afghanistan, India, the Islamic Republic of Iran and Kyrgyzstan to participate in this meeting.

In accordance with rule 39 of the Council's provisional rules of procedure, I invite the following briefers to participate in this meeting: Ms. Roza Otunbayeva, Special Representative of the Secretary-General for Afghanistan and Head of the United Nations Assistance Mission in Afghanistan; and Ms. Hanifa Girowal.

The Security Council will now begin its consideration of the item on its agenda.

I wish to draw the attention of Council members to document S/2025/554, which contains the report of the Secretary-General on the situation in Afghanistan and its implications for international peace and security.

I give the floor to Ms. Otunbayeva.

Ms. Otunbayeva: Shortly before my arrival in Afghanistan three years ago, a devastating earthquake struck the country's south-east, like the earthquake that recently struck several eastern provinces of the country. At that time, I visited the site, met with victims and discussed cooperation with the local de facto authorities. I saw the desperation of the people affected and their need for assistance and the efforts of the local de facto authorities. I urged the international community to provide funds, and the United Nations family worked selflessly in cooperation with the de facto authorities to provide immediate and then long-term aid.

Several months later, however, the de facto authorities issued a ban on higher education for women, exacerbating the existing ban on secondary education, and a ban on Afghan women working for non-governmental organizations, later extended to United Nations organizations. These decisions show the different trends vying for influence within the de facto authorities — one that is more pragmatic and oriented to the needs of Afghan people and the other more focused on the creation of what is described as a pure Islamic system, and that has placed increasing restrictions on the Afghan people. In view of the lack of pragmatism, members of the international community increasingly ask how much they should support a country whose leaders undermine their population.

This is most clear regarding the de facto authorities' policies towards Afghan women. After three and a half years since the closure of girls' schools beyond grade six, a generation is at serious risk of being lost, at a huge long-term cost to the country and causing enormous concern and despair among Afghan society as a whole. A recent survey by UN-Women found that the vast majority of Afghans oppose the ban on girls' education. The World Bank estimates that it costs the economy $1.4 billion per year.

I have spent the past three years advocating for engagement with the de facto authorities, based on the mandate given by the Council and the demonstrated willingness of the pragmatic faction to improve the lives of Afghan people and relations with the international community, and based on the evidence that progress through engagement can be made on some issues for the benefit of the Afghan people. The engagement of the United Nations Assistance Mission in Afghanistan (UNAMA)

built on the groundwork laid prior to my appointment, shortly after the Taliban takeover, when cooperative discussions allowed for the provision of humanitarian assistance. The de facto authorities made commitments on humanitarian access and the safety and security of humanitarian workers and compounds. In December 2021, the Council adopted resolution 2615 (2021), which clarified that the provision of humanitarian and basic human needs assistance did not violate financial sanctions outlined in the United Nations sanctions regime pursuant to resolution 1988 (2011). The United States issued General Licence 20 in February 2022, which authorized all financial transactions involving Afghanistan, or governing institutions in Afghanistan, except for certain listed individuals. These measures helped to avert famine and probably saved thousands of lives during that first uncertain winter. These exemptions continue to have a positive impact on the Afghan people, enabling sustained humanitarian and basic human needs responses.

Since 2021, the international community has provided nearly $13 billion of international assistance: $7.9 billion for humanitarian funding and $4.9 billion for basic human needs. Despite some reports to the contrary, for the most part this has been distributed without major interference. The United Nations has strengthened risk management and monitoring systems to minimize the risk of aid diversion. The United Nations also assumed responsibility for handling cash shipments required for humanitarian operations, necessary at a time at which Afghanistan was facing a severe fiscal and liquidity crisis. Without these early cash shipments, the humanitarian response would have collapsed, with catastrophic consequences for the Afghan people.

I would like to point to a few positive developments since August 2021 and the takeover by the de facto authorities.

Afghanistan has experienced a notable decline in large-scale armed conflict and violence, resulting in a relatively stable security environment across much of the country, despite ongoing challenges such as the presence of extremist groups, widespread humanitarian and economic hardship and human rights concerns.

The ban on poppy cultivation has generally been sustained since enforcement began in the spring of 2023. This has benefits for the region and globally and should benefit the Afghan people over time. In the short term, however, the ban's impact on many poor, rural Afghans, who relied on poppy cultivation for their livelihoods and who, in some provinces, were the early supporters of the Taliban as an insurgency, has been devastating. This population now criticizes the de facto authorities for not doing enough to provide alternative livelihoods, risking a renewed increase in poppy cultivation, and for detaining poppy farmers.

The announcement by the de facto authorities of a general amnesty in August 2021 was also constructive. UNAMA continues to document cases in which the amnesty has been violated. Each violation is reprehensible and should be addressed, but general compliance is encouraging after decades of a brutal war.

In 2022, the Taliban leader issued several texts aligned with certain international human rights obligations, including decisions prohibiting torture and on the right to defence lawyers. While much remains to be done on the rights and treatment of detainees, constructive engagement between UNAMA human rights teams and the de facto Office of Prison Administration has allowed and facilitated human rights teams' access to all 34 prisons countrywide, in which they regularly conduct visits and engage with detainees.

Some States are still seeking to repatriate Afghans who worked for them during the era of the Republic to their own countries. The United Nations is also aware that several States are negotiating with the de facto authorities on the return of Afghans from their countries to Afghanistan. While doing so, we continue to urge Members States to refrain from involuntarily returning individuals at risk of human

rights violations to Afghanistan, and to increase the availability of safe pathways for Afghans at risk to leave the country.

To support engagement, the United Nations comprehensive approach to Afghanistan, based on Security Council resolution 2721 (2023) and under the Doha process, seeks to maintain a basic international consensus on Afghanistan, through two lines of endeavour: working groups advancing collective efforts on counter-narcotics and enabling the private sector and, secondly, building confidence among stakeholders, and the mosaic approach. It provides the only multilateral framework for engagement between the international community and the de facto authorities and a political pathway to address the complex issues blocking Afghanistan's reintegration into the international system which, ultimately, must be based on the de facto authorities acting on their basic international obligations. If advanced, this framework could allow for Afghanistan to reach its full economic potential and develop its human capital, for both men and women.

The development of Afghanistan's full potential is necessary for the country to address the multiple and simultaneous crises it is currently facing. The main aspects are as follows.

First, the growing number and enforcement of restrictions against men, women, girls and minorities, particularly by de facto Propagation of Virtue and the Prevention of Vice inspectors, is giving rise to increasing popular discontent with the de facto authorities. People are telling us that the Taliban leadership should instead focus more on issues that matter most to the Afghan people, such as employment, the economy, education and public services.

Secondly, aid cuts of almost 50 per cent in 2025, with the likelihood of further reductions next year, are another reason. It must be acknowledged that these cuts are partly the result of Afghanistan's anti-women policies.

Thirdly, the economy is struggling. Its 2.7 per cent growth rate is below the population growth rate, not counting the recent returns. Currently, 75 per cent of the population lives at subsistence levels — a serious situation compounded by recent significant cuts to the public sector.

Fourthly, there is an emerging drought and other climate-related stressors, including natural disasters, such as the recent earthquake in eastern Afghanistan. Afghanistan's economy is primarily agricultural. The majority of its people live in rural areas, and many of them are subsistence farmers. A drought presents an existential threat. Water shortages have already led to significant internal migration, which creates additional stress factors on society and the economy. Water also affects urban populations. In the next years, not decades, Kabul — a city of almost 6 million — could become the first modern city to run out of water.

Fifthly, significant population returns from neighbouring countries are stressing existing socioeconomic coping mechanisms. More than 2 million Afghans have returned in the past two years, with 1.8 million people returning since the beginning of this year alone. Unlike with the wave of returnees in late 2023, limited international resources are available now to assist in the reception and resettlement of returnees. I have been to Afghanistan's border with Pakistan and Iran, and I have seen how the de facto authorities are doing what they can with the very limited resources they have to receive their returning citizens. These returns have also cost the economy approximately $1 billion in remittances.

It is an open question whether there is sufficient pragmatism among the de facto authorities to manage this perfect storm of crises, or whether decisions driven by ideology will prevent sustainable solutions, extending the suffering of Afghan people and undermining the existing stability.

We have seen evidence of both trends recently. In response to the Kunar earthquake, the de facto authorities mobilized helicopters to evacuate the wounded, coordinated with international agencies and countries providing bilateral aid, set up sites for internally displaced people and addressed the immediate and medium-term needs of the affected communities in other ways. At the same time, as United Nations agencies were ramping up their support for earthquake victims while continuing their assistance to the returnee crisis, personnel from the de facto Ministry of Defence deployed outside United Nations compounds in Kabul, preventing access for our female national staff. Similarly, personnel from the de facto Ministry of Interior's directorate in charge of protecting the United Nations have blocked access for female national staff to United Nations field office premises around the country.

This serious restriction hinders the United Nations ability to help the Afghan people in their moment of great need. I visited Kunar several days ago. The devastation caused was much greater compared to the other two Paktika and Herat earthquakes in the past three years. I was struck by this deep tragedy and the generous support of the international community. International financial institutions, such as the World Bank and the Asian Development Bank, are also involved in mobilizing funds for basic human needs and services. But these projects funded by international financial institutions must be implemented through United Nations agencies, and their impact has been reduced by the enforcement of bans against female national staff and the wider ban on women working, which has created unacceptable discrimination. We have issued a statement calling for this ban and its enforcement to be lifted, and I urge the Security Council to echo our call.

As I prepare to leave Afghanistan in a few days, I am certain that most Afghans want engagement between the international community and their country to continue, despite the obstacles. It is my fervent hope that a pathway can be agreed for this engagement to continue and for it to begin to yield more positive results, especially for women and girls in Afghanistan. I thank the Council for the steadfast support provided to UNAMA and call for continued Council unity on Afghanistan. I thank my colleagues in the United Nations and especially my colleagues on the ground in UNAMA and the United Nations country team for their unwavering dedication to this common cause, their humanity and their determination to support the Afghan people.

The President: I thank Ms. Otunbayeva for her briefing.

I now give the floor to Ms. Girowal.

Ms. Girowal: First, let me thank you, Mr. President, and the Republic of Korea for allowing me to brief the Security Council.

I am Hanifa Girowal, Vice President of Women's Rights First, an Afghan women-led organization that advocates for women and girls and documents violations against women and girls in Afghanistan. Today I speak on behalf of thousands of Afghan women both in the country and in exile with whom I have spoken while preparing my talking points to convey a stark truth: Afghanistan is currently facing the worst human rights, humanitarian, environmental and political crises in its history, which is going to have an impact not only on us, the Afghan people, but also on the stability of the region and global peace.

The situation in Afghanistan is well-known to this Council, and it is hardly disputed, except by the Taliban, whose credibility remains in tatters. The question should not be what is happening on the ground but rather what the international community and the Council can do to end it.

On the fourth anniversary of the ban on girls' education, a young woman from Kandahar told me with a trembling voice: by now, I should have completed my master's degree and become a law professor at Kandahar University. Instead, for four long

years, I have lived in uncertainty, unable to decide my own future. How much longer must I wait? Her words capture the silent suffering of a generation whose dreams and lives have been deliberately suffocated. This is not just a denial of education; it is a deliberate policy of forced confinement, exclusion and subjugation and the systematic deprivation of women and girls of their basic rights, which amounts to the crime against humanity of gender persecution and is what the Special Rapporteur on the situation of human rights in Afghanistan called gender apartheid. Moreover, excluding half the population is not only a human rights violation; it creates the very fragility in which terrorist groups thrive and economic development becomes impossible.

I am not here to register despair but rather to assert four demands that the Council can address immediately.

First, humanitarian aid is essential, and it must continue. It must be unconditional in its purpose and conditional only on its accountability. The Council should adopt a resolution that reaffirms the unconditionality of humanitarian assistance, guarantees United Nations and international non-governmental organizations access without political interference and creates an independent and internationally appointed monitoring mechanism with remote verification and the legal accountability to find and report on aid diversions and hold donors accountable.

Secondly, the mandate of the United Nations Assistance Mission in Afghanistan (UNAMA) must be maintained, and its implementation must be strengthened, with a focus on finding a political solution and facilitating an intra-Afghan dialogue. This includes ensuring that the Afghan people, in particular Afghan women, lead the process and are part of any discussion on the future of the country. We recommend creating a specific architecture, under the auspices of UNAMA, to host an intra-Afghan dialogue in the light of the independent assessment by the Special Coordinator, which recommended the formulation of a political road map that can fully integrate Afghanistan into the international community.

Thirdly, there is a need to establish rights-based benchmarks that are tied to engagement with the Taliban. We propose three immediate, verifiable benchmarks: a demand on the Taliban de facto authorities to allow women and girls to receive secondary and tertiary education; the restoration of women's ability to work in the humanitarian and the public sectors; and the restoration of unfettered access for United Nations human rights and humanitarian monitors, including the Special Rapporteur on the situation of human rights in Afghanistan. The Council should link international incentives and targeted relief to measurable progress on these benchmarks through the travel-and-benefit architectures of the Security Council Committee established pursuant to resolution 1988 (2011).

Fourthly, forced returns to Afghanistan must be prevented. History will remember that while Afghanistan was going through one of its most challenging trials, our neighbouring countries, Iran and Pakistan, and our international allies such as Germany and Türkiye subjected millions of Afghans to involuntarily return. In 2025 alone, Iran and Pakistan have forced more than 2.6 million Afghans to return to Afghanistan. These actions have led to fear, deprivation, imprisonment and the killing of former Afghan National Defence and Security Forces staff members. Sending back women and girls subjects them to unimaginable levels of targeted and systematic persecution.

Eligible Afghans with asylum cases who were waiting in Pakistan to be resettled in Germany and other countries, including the United States, have been subjected to forced deportation by the Pakistani authorities. While the Council cannot legislate national asylum systems, it can and must urge all States to uphold their obligations under international law, in particular the principle of non-refoulement, which is codified under the 1951 Convention relating to the Status of Refugees and the 1984

Convention against Torture — to which most Council members, including Pakistan, are signatories. The Council can also request that the Secretary-General report on patterns of forced returns and consider establishing regional humanitarian hubs outside Kabul, where necessary, to ensure that aid reaches returnees without passing through politicized or gender-exclusive gatekeepers.

Besides these three main requests, the Council must pay attention to climate stress, which is compounding every one of these crises. Record droughts, worsening floods and shrinking glaciers in the Hindu Kush have already reduced harvests and damaged water systems, deepening food insecurity, driving immigration and intensifying competition over scarce resources. Women and girls are paying the heaviest price. Decades of conflict have left explosive remnants contaminating our air, soil and water. After the recent earthquake, the United Nations confirmed that unexploded ordnance blocked relief teams from reaching victims in eastern Afghanistan. In addition, tragically, the Taliban did not allow female aid workers and doctors to support the response efforts. Many injured women and pregnant women lost their lives in the aftermath due to the lack of female doctors and the Taliban's restrictions on male aid workers touching the bodies of wounded women.

We are running out of time. The situation on the ground is only getting worse. As of two weeks ago, not only are women and girls not allowed into regular schools, they also are now banned from going to Islamic schools and madrasas. In the province of Kandahar, the Taliban has also just dictated that tall girls — anyone above an average height — cannot go outside and must be confined to their homes. The economic situation is also worsening, with increased food insecurity and millions on the verge of hunger, which is increasing child marriages, maternal mortality rate and gender abuse. Those girls who had a glimmer of hope of continuing their informal studies through online programmes are also now faced with internet outages and the denial of access to online education. As of now, women in Afghanistan are faced with selective punishment for any public engagement.

All that I have shared is bad news, but the good news is that the Council can do something about it. Council members must also be creative: expand remote education and scholarship pipelines for girls, inside and outside Afghanistan; fund women-led consortia that directly manage aid for communities and support independent Afghan media and civil society, particularly women-led society organizations, through secure trust funds; support the establishment of a comprehensive accountability mechanism in addition to the mandate of the Special Rapporteur on the situation of human rights in Afghanistan; and expand resettlement and protection pathways for those most at risk, including women human rights defenders, journalists and civic activists.

Lastly, let us not allow history to remember that when Afghanistan required the institutional fortitude of the international community, expedience was prioritized over the obligations under the Charter of the United Nations and the norms that bind us all. Let the response to the Afghan crisis be the test case of the international community's solidarity and effective diplomacy.

The President: I thank Ms. Girowal for her briefing.

I shall now give the floor to those members of the Council who wish to make statements.

Mrs. Rodrigues-Birkett (Guyana): I have the honour to deliver this statement on behalf of the three African members of the Security Council, namely, Algeria, Sierra Leone, Somalia, as well as my own country, Guyana (A3+).

We thank the Special Representative of the Secretary-General and Head of the United Nations Assistance Mission in Afghanistan (UNAMA), Ms. Roza Otunbayeva, for her briefing. We have also listened carefully to Ms. Hanifa Girowal.

We stand in solidarity with the Afghan people, following the recent devastating earthquake. We encourage the international community to render much-needed support to the people of Afghanistan. The A3+ reiterates its firm commitment to the sovereignty, independence, territorial integrity and national unity of Afghanistan and reaffirms its unwavering solidarity with the Afghan people.

Afghanistan is grappling with worsening conditions due to displacement, poverty, food insecurity and a fragile economy. These challenges are further exacerbated by funding shortfalls, which have forced humanitarian partners to reduce or suspend essential operations, leaving millions without much-needed support. It is troubling that, as of 27 August, the Afghanistan humanitarian needs and response plan has received only 27 per cent of the $2.4 billion requested. In this regard, we are deeply concerned that hunger continues to impact much of the country, with 9.5 million projected to face acute levels of food insecurity between May and October 2025. We commend UNICEF for its efforts in providing more than 19 million children with essential healthcare and the Food and Agriculture Organization for providing livelihood assistance and other support to those in need. Ensuring the well-being of the Afghan people must remain at the centre of all efforts. The worsening humanitarian crisis in Afghanistan is of particular concern, and the reduction in foreign aid poses significant risks of increased poverty and a mounting food insecurity crisis in Afghanistan.

The A3+ is concerned about reports of access-related incidents, resulting in the suspension of humanitarian activities and making access difficult for those in need of humanitarian aid. We take note that reported challenges linked to the Taliban accounted for 73 per cent of incidents affecting humanitarian activities, including the detention of 100 humanitarian workers, 31 of whom were women, and 12 United Nations personnel.

We also recall that resolution 2681 (2023), which was unanimously adopted by the Council, condemned the decision of the Taliban to ban women from working for the United Nations in Afghanistan. The ban has negatively affected United Nations operations in the country, including the delivery of life-saving assistance and basic services to the most vulnerable. We emphasize the importance of women working for the United Nations and humanitarian organizations in ensuring the delivery of aid to those in need, in particular women and girls. We reiterate our call on the Taliban to facilitate unhindered and sustained access to humanitarian aid to all those in need across Afghanistan and encourage international donors and humanitarian partners to continue providing critical support and to scale up contributions.

The A3+ is alarmed at the 191 grave violations affecting at least 130 children, including 22 girls, documented by the Afghanistan country task force on monitoring and reporting on children and armed conflict from 1 April to 30 June, with killing and maiming being the most prevalent violations. Unexploded ordnance continues to cause significant harm to children. We commend the Mine Action Service for its clearance and risk-education activities, funded through the Special Trust Fund for Afghanistan. We call on the Taliban to urgently address the threat of explosive devices.

The situation of women and girls remains of grave concern. The rights of women and girls continue to be significantly curtailed in all civic spaces, as the Taliban continues to intensify its campaign to enforce the law on the Propagation of Virtue and the Prevention of Vice, restricting their education, employment, freedom of movement and freedom of expression. While schools and universities have reopened globally, Afghan women and girls continue to be denied access to education beyond grade 6. The A3+ strongly reiterates its call on the Taliban to reopen all schools and universities and to swiftly reverse all laws, policies and practices that discriminate against women and girls and infringe their human rights and fundamental freedoms. We emphasize that the full, equal and meaningful participation and leadership

of women in all spheres of life is necessary for Afghanistan's development and prosperity. The continued erosion of Afghan women in society is unacceptable.

The 9 per cent increase in security-related incidents compared to the same period in 2024 is concerning, particularly regarding the safety and security of humanitarian personnel. We call on the Taliban to ensure the safety and security of humanitarian personnel. We also remain concerned about the situation of terrorism in Afghanistan and urge the countries of the region to increase their efforts to address and deter security threats. The A3+ reiterates that engagement between Afghanistan and the international community is crucial for its sustainable peace and stability and social and economic development. We commend UNAMA for convening its second meeting on the private sector working group and its third meeting of the counter-narcotics working group in Doha. We also applaud UNAMA for its inclusive approach in this regard. We call on the Taliban to uphold Afghanistan's international obligations to protect, promote and fulfil the rights and well-being of all Afghans.

In conclusion, the A3+ reaffirms its full support for UNAMA and Special Representative Otunbayeva.

Mr. Kelley (United States of America): Let me thank the Special Representative of the Secretary-General for her briefing. I also thank Ms. Hanifa Girowal for her remarks.

First, the United States would like to express its sorrow for the loss of life and destruction caused by the recent earthquakes. We extend our heartfelt condolences to the Afghan people during this time. Unfortunately, the Taliban's oppressive policies have hindered the response to this disaster, just as Taliban policies have exacerbated many other hardships for the people of Afghanistan. Just days ago, the Taliban prevented female United Nations aid workers from providing aid in Afghanistan to help victims of the earthquake, directly resulting in additional casualties.

As we heard today, the people of Afghanistan continue to endure significant challenges, including poverty, unemployment, limited access to basic services and recurring natural disasters. And unfortunately, the international community's approach to assistance and engagement has failed to yield sustainable results. As President Trump has made clear, the United States prioritizes actions over words. The Taliban's actions do not demonstrate a willingness to engage in good faith. We remain deeply sceptical of its willingness to meet its international commitments or to respect Afghanistan's international obligations.

This concern applies to the Doha process. While the United States continues to participate in the process and its working groups, we are deeply sceptical of the Taliban's motives. We cannot build confidence with a group that continues to detain innocent Americans, fails to live up to its counter-terrorism commitments and ignores the basic needs of the Afghan people. For decades, the United States, along with many other Member States, sacrificed lives and billions of dollars to support the people of Afghanistan. It is time for the Taliban to act.

The United States' top priority in Afghanistan remains the protection of United States citizens and the homeland, which includes mitigating terrorist threats emanating from Afghanistan and securing the release of all unjustly detained Americans. It is in the mutual interest of us all on the Security Council to ensure that Afghanistan never again harbours terrorists and that the Taliban makes progress on its counter-terrorism commitments and does not engage in hostage diplomacy.

The Council must continue to demand responsible actions from the Taliban. The people of Afghanistan deserve no less. We must also keep in mind that, at a time when budgets are under heightened scrutiny, special political missions, including the

United Nations Assistance Mission in Afghanistan, must refocus on their core task of promoting peace and security, guided by clear performance benchmarks.

Mr. Nebenzia (Russian Federation) (*spoke in Russian*): We thank the Special Representative of the Secretary-General and Head of the United Nations Assistance Mission in Afghanistan (UNAMA), Ms. Roza Otunbayeva, for her briefing on the situation in the country. We took careful note of the statement by the civil society representative, Ms. Hanifa Girowal. We also welcome the opportunity afforded to regional stakeholders to contribute to today's discussion.

First and foremost, we wish to express our sincere condolences to the leadership and the people of Afghanistan in the wake of the calamitous earthquake in Nangarhar province on 31 August, which killed more than 2,000 and injured 3,600 people to varying degrees of severity. The Russian Federation acted promptly to deliver two consignments of humanitarian aid totalling 40 tons, including food, tents and blankets for those affected by the disaster.

The Russian Federation has consistently supported UNAMA in the execution of its mandated tasks. We note Kabul's expressed interest in maintaining and developing its engagement with the Mission. We take this opportunity to thank Ms. Roza Otunbayeva for her able stewardship of UNAMA over these years and for her personal contribution to the promotion of broad international assistance to the country.

We have taken due note of the Secretary-General's report on the situation in Afghanistan (S/2025/554). In that regard, we would like to offer the following observations.

The Taliban's current rule in Afghanistan has entered its fifth year. The new authorities inherited a country that had been dependent on international support for two decades. That period was marked by instability and the presence of United States and NATO forces that totally controlled the country until their ignominious and hasty withdrawal. Yet despite unprecedented unilateral sanctions, terrorist threats and humanitarian and economic crises, Afghanistan has proved its resilience. Fortunately, the predictions of its imminent collapse made by our Western colleagues failed to materialize. Unlike their predecessors, the new authorities chose not to wait for Western assistance. Instead, they opted for regional cooperation with a focus on restoring the country's socioeconomic potential and achieving its independent development. Their ambition is understandable: they want to see Afghanistan transformed into an independent, free, stable and prosperous State, living in peace and cooperation with its neighbours. This is precisely the aim of the new national development strategy. However, it is clear that, given the magnitude of the accumulated threats and challenges, the recovery process will take time. The country's long-suffering people have never been in greater need of our sustained and depoliticized assistance. This is our shared responsibility.

We have consistently emphasized the need for a realistic and comprehensive approach to Afghanistan based on objective analysis and a balanced assessment of the situation. Its core elements remain unchanged, namely, constructive engagement by the international community on the Afghan issue, with due regard for the needs of the Afghan people and free of double standards. This approach also implies a meticulous dialogue with the Taliban on all pressing matters, without resorting to pressure or blackmail. There is no alternative to that course of action. We have said as much from the very outset. That specific approach has found the support of all regional players, first and foremost the participants in the Moscow format. The frequent contact among Russia, China, Iran and Pakistan on Afghanistan confirms this. The latest such meeting took place in Dushanbe on 11 September. This same approach, we are told, also underpins United Nations efforts. The Taliban are also

keen to foster such a mutually respectful dialogue with the international community, having participated in the working groups on counter-narcotics and private sector issues held in the framework of the Doha process in June 2024. It is encouraging that a number of pragmatic Western colleagues have already understood the flaws of such policies of pressure and are inclined to resume broad humanitarian assistance and development.

Against this backdrop, it is regrettable that some Western donors are engaging in futile attempts to exert a stranglehold on the Taliban by addressing them in the language of ultimatums and simultaneously obstructing any efforts, including those of the United Nations, to engage with them on the basis of trust. Furthermore, the new United States policy of politicizing the work of the Committee established pursuant to resolution 1988 (2011) on sanctions against the Taliban movement and exploiting it for its own narrow interests is wholly unjustifiable. Such actions only hinder regional players' efforts to resolve key issues.

We concur with the Secretary-General's assessment of the complex domestic political situation in Afghanistan. We are concerned about the persistent security risks posed by the terrorist activities of the Islamic State in Iraq and the Levant-Khorasan group. We take note of the Taliban's efforts but see that these measures are, unfortunately, inadequate. Terrorists hold increasing sway in the country and are deliberately destabilizing the situation in a bid to portray themselves as an alternative force and to destabilize Afghanistan and the region. The fighters have themselves confirmed that the terrorist group benefits from funding from abroad and that foreign terrorist fighters are among their ranks, including those who gained combat experience in Syria and Iraq. Given the quantity of weapons that Western military forces left in the country, the threat of those arms falling into the fighters' hands and spreading beyond the region is becoming very real. There are clear risks of terrorism spreading to Central Asia and beyond. Comprehensive measures are needed to combat terrorism, eradicate all terrorist groups and prevent Afghan territory from being used for terrorist purposes, including against other States.

The narcotics problem is closely bound to terrorism. The Taliban's efforts continue to be inadequate. Comprehensive international and regional assistance, including through the United Nations Office on Drugs and Crime, remains crucial. The threat of synthetic narcotics production demands particular attention. Support for Afghan farmers is also of continuing importance.

The socioeconomic situation in the country is one of our utmost priorities. We commend United Nations and regional organizations' efforts to provide humanitarian assistance to Afghanistan. The selfless endeavours of all humanitarian agencies, including the Office of the United Nations High Commissioner for Refugees, and their staff on the ground, who stand ready, in all circumstances, to help Afghans, deserve high praise, especially given the financial crisis, dwindling donor assistance and the return of Afghan refugees en masse. At the same time, it is regrettable that humanitarian workers' attempts to extend assistance beyond basic needs continue to be blocked by a number of Western donors, who categorically object to any possibility of helping the country to develop, including by unfreezing Afghan assets abroad, restoring civilian infrastructure and building roads to link provinces and cities to agricultural areas. This hypocritical approach does not seek genuine solutions that could truly transform the situation in Afghanistan, and in no way will it help ordinary Afghans, including women, girls and children, the importance of support for whom is much discussed in the Chamber.

Russia routinely provides aid to those in need in Afghanistan. We are consistently expanding bilateral cooperation in the commercial and economic spheres and fostering business dialogue and opportunities, including by involving the authorities in the international economic forums that our country convenes. We are monitoring

closely developments in terms of human rights for all Afghans, including women and girls, and the formation of a genuinely inclusive Government with the participation of all ethnic and political groups nationwide. We underline the importance of respecting fundamental rights and freedoms, including the right to education and to work, and of taking into account the needs of all Afghans, including ethnic and religious minorities. We look forward to seeing positive developments in both areas.

The Russian Federation fully supports the right and desire of the Afghan people to live in a peaceful and prosperous country — one that is free from drugs and terrorism. This is the key to order and stability in the region. However, fostering such long-term, sustainable peace will be impossible without patient interaction with the authorities, which does not entail imposing on them one's own vision and priorities. At the same time, it is important that we in the United Nations communicate with those Afghans who represent the real authorities in the country and who are actually responsible for what is happening there. The swift resolution of the current impasse and the subsequent international reintegration of Afghanistan depend on this.

Mr. Bonnafont (France) (*spoke in French*): First of all, I would like to thank the Special Representative of the Secretary-General, Ms. Roza Otunbayeva, and commend her work at the helm of United Nations Assistance Mission in Afghanistan (UNAMA) over the past three years. France extends its full support to her and all United Nations staff in Afghanistan. I also thank Ms. Hanifa Girowal, Vice-President of Women's Rights First, for her briefing, and I welcome the representatives of Afghanistan, Kyrgyzstan, Iran and India.

In a few days' time, the United Nations will mark the thirtieth anniversary of the Fourth World Conference on Women, and it is with that in mind that the Security Council must assess the situation of women in Afghanistan at the hands of the Taliban.

First, the Council must condemn the Taliban's decision to restrict women's access to humanitarian aid, amid a devastating earthquake, which has claimed countless victims. France is outraged at the Taliban's denial of assistance to Afghan women, which is condemning thousands, mainly women and children, to death.

Secondly, France once again calls on the Taliban to end restrictions on humanitarian actors in the country. The prohibition on female Afghan employees' access to United Nations premises in Kabul and other cities in the country comes to mind, all the more so when the country is confronting the consequences of this devastating earthquake. The basic rule must be a straightforward one: distribution of aid by and for women. Thoughts also turn to the pressure being exerted on UNAMA staff in the country; the Council must support UNAMA's call on the Taliban to ease the pressure and the restrictions.

Thirdly, the international community and the Council must take stock of the gravity of the decisions that the Taliban have been taking for the past four years. When the Council met in June (see S/PV.9942), we underscored Afghanistan's international obligations, which the Taliban must fulfil and which the Council laid down in its resolution 2593 (2021). However, the situation is worsening. The Taliban are stepping up their violations of human rights, particularly against women and girls, not only in terms of humanitarian aid but, more generally, through a policy of making women and girls invisible and segregating them.

As regards security, the monitoring team, which reports to the Committee established pursuant to resolution 1267 (1999), 1989 (2011) and 2253 (2015) has documented the Taliban's lenience towards Al-Qaida, which is still active in Afghanistan, while Islamic State in Iraq and the Levant-Khorasan continues to pose an acute threat to international peace and security.

In this extremely grave context, France stands alongside the Afghan population, women and girls who every day face the brutality of the Taliban's ideology.

The quest for justice of the Afghan people is also our quest. France is making the fight against impunity a priority. We welcome the issuance by the International Criminal Court in July of two arrest warrants against Taliban leaders on the grounds of gender-based persecution, a crime against humanity under the Rome Statute. France also supports the establishment of an independent investigation mechanism to shed light on the crimes committed in Afghanistan.

Finally, France hears those who call for engagement with the Taliban. France has never closed the door to dialogue and has participated in the Doha process. But we must not lose sight of the goal: peace in Afghanistan and respect for the rights of all Afghans. Women, young people and members of civil society must have their place in discussions on the future of their country, which cannot be written without them.

Mr. Kariuki (United Kingdom): I thank the Special Representative of the Secretary-General for Afghanistan, Ms. Otunbayeva, and Ms. Girowal for their briefings today.

We commend the work of the United Nations Assistance Mission in Afghanistan (UNAMA), the Office for the Coordination of Humanitarian Affairs and UN-Women in support of the people of Afghanistan. And I would like to convey the United Kingdom's gratitude to the Special Representative of the Secretary-General for Afghanistan, Ms. Otunbayeva, for her leadership of these efforts over the past three years.

I will make three points.

First, I offer the United Kingdom's deep condolences to all the victims of the devastating earthquake on 31 August. I pay tribute to all those working tirelessly to bring relief to those affected. The specific needs of women affected by the earthquake must be met, and female aid workers must be able to operate in affected communities. As we have heard today, the earthquake has compounded the desperate humanitarian and economic crisis in Afghanistan. In recognition of the severity of the situation, the United Kingdom yesterday announced an uplift of more than $4 million in its support to the earthquake response, bringing its total contribution to $5.4 million. But we are concerned by increasing drought risks and alarming increases in malnutrition. More support is urgently needed, in particular to ensure that Afghans living in remote areas do not go hungry this winter. We call on the Taliban and the international community to step up their support to the people of Afghanistan.

Secondly, Afghanistan cannot succeed while women and girls are excluded. In this regard, we are concerned by reports that the Taliban are preventing female employees from accessing United Nations premises. We call on the Taliban to reverse this position immediately, to ensure that Afghan women can continue their vital work supporting their country.

Thirdly, the United Kingdom continues to engage with the United Nations-led process, including the comprehensive approach. But our support is conditional on the Taliban taking meaningful steps and adhering to their international obligations, especially those related to counter-terrorism and the rights of women and girls.

The United Kingdom remains committed to finding a constructive way forward, working with international partners and Afghan stakeholders. But four years on from their seizure of power, we need to see more from the Taliban to demonstrate that they are willing to engage in good faith. The United Kingdom continues to stand with the people of Afghanistan. It is well past time for the Taliban to do the same.

Mr. Geng Shuang (China) (*spoke in Chinese*): I welcome you, Mr. President, to New York to preside over today's meeting, and I thank the Special Representative of the Secretary-General for Afghanistan, Ms. Otunbayeva, and Ms. Girowal for their briefings.

The current situation in Afghanistan is generally stable. There have been some improvements in the economy and in people's livelihoods and a gradual increase in the country's interactions with the wider world. Meanwhile, in areas such as humanitarian, development, human rights and counter-terrorism efforts, multiple challenges persist. The international community should take an objective, impartial, rational and pragmatic approach to the Afghan issue, strengthen unity and build consensus to help the country to get on the right track without delay and to integrate it into the international community.

I will make a few points.

First, we should maintain engagement and dialogue with Afghanistan and enhance our understanding of and mutual trust with the country. In recent years, regional mechanisms, including the foreign ministers' meeting of Afghanistan's neighbours, the Shanghai Cooperation Organization, Moscow format consultations and the China-Afghanistan-Pakistan Foreign Ministers' Dialogue, together with the Doha process led by the United Nations, have played a positive role in enhancing communication and exchanges between the international community and Afghanistan. However, owing to various factors past and present, mutual integration between the international community and Afghanistan can proceed only step by step, and long-term commitment is required to deliver success. In this regard, active interactions and continuous engagements between the two sides are indispensable. It is of concern to us that recently, at the Committee established pursuant to resolution 1988 (2011), one country, on multiple occasions, repeatedly cited the detention of its citizens by Afghan authorities as the reason for blocking travel ban exemption requests for senior Afghan Government officials, seriously disrupting Afghanistan's normal exchanges with the international community. That practice plainly abused the sanctions tool of the Security Council to serve national interests, provoking discontent among many members of the Security Council. We urge the country in question to change this practice immediately and once again call on the 1988 Committee to reinstate comprehensive travel ban exemption arrangements without delay.

Secondly, we should scale up assistance and help Afghanistan to overcome its difficulties. It was noted in the report of the Secretary-General (S/2025/554) that approximately 23 million Afghans need humanitarian assistance, and 9.5 million face an acute shortage of food. Significant funding cuts by major donors mean that less than 30 per cent of the funding needs have been met this year. The recent earthquakes in eastern Afghanistan exacerbated this humanitarian crisis. We commend the United Nations Assistance Mission in Afghanistan (UNAMA) and the Office for the Coordination of Humanitarian Affairs, among other agencies, and many countries for extending a helping hand to Afghanistan. China has recently announced the donation of earthquake emergency humanitarian supplies of 50 million yuan to Afghanistan. Given these huge humanitarian needs, we call upon traditional donors to scale up their funding support and to stop politicizing humanitarian relief. We call on a certain country to assume its historical responsibilities, resume aid to Afghans, halt unilateral sanctions and provide necessary support for humanitarian action.

Thirdly, we should strengthen positive guidance and promote the protection of the rights and interests of the Afghan people. Women account for nearly half of the Afghan population. Securing their equal access to education, healthcare, employment and participation in public affairs is imperative for Afghanistan's peace, stability, development and prosperity and to meet the expectations of the international community. We call on the Afghan Government to exercise moderate and inclusive

governance and put in place effective measures to safeguard the basic rights and interests of all Afghans, including women. UNAMA has recently issued a statement expressing concern over the Afghan Government preventing Afghan women from working for the United Nations. We call on the Government of Afghanistan to strengthen friendly consultations with UNAMA to properly resolve such issues and to ensure the normal functioning of United Nations agencies and United Nations humanitarian relief work in Afghanistan.

Fourthly, we should remove any obstacles to development and support Afghanistan's Indigenous development. The Afghan Government has recently launched its national development strategy, actively promoting economic reconstruction and integration into regional cooperation. Meanwhile, the Secretary-General's report identifies economic isolation and limited access to financing, among other things, as significant constraints on Afghan economic growth. We call on the relevant countries to unconditionally return the Afghan Central Bank's overseas assets and support the reconstruction of its financial system so that it can unlock its development potential. We support Afghanistan in further strengthening connectivity and economic and trade cooperation with countries of the region. We expect the two working groups of the Doha process to play a greater role in helping Afghanistan to boost its economic dynamism, promote alternative cultivation, treat and rehabilitate drug users, sustain development momentum and build on counter-narcotics achievements.

Fifthly, we should strengthen counter-terrorism efforts and maintain security in Afghanistan and the region. The Secretary-General's report states that terrorist threats in Afghanistan remain prominent. The Islamic State in Iraq and the Levant-Khorasan, the Eastern Turkistan Islamic Movement and Tehrik-e Taliban Pakistan, among other terrorist groups, remain active in Afghanistan and have conspired with foreign terrorist elements to plan and launch attacks, undermining Afghan and regional security. We call on the Afghan Government to enhance counter-terrorism efforts and coordination with regional countries and prevent terrorist organizations from exploiting Afghan territory to undermine the security of other countries. When it comes to counter-terrorism, we must stand firmly against double standards and selectivity and must maintain international cooperation in combating terrorism.

Since assuming office, Special Representative Otunbayeva has led UNAMA in pushing for engagement and dialogue between the Afghan authorities and the international community, responding to humanitarian and development crises and protecting the basic rights and interests of the Afghan people. We highly commend her efforts and contributions and wish her all the best in the future. As a friendly neighbour of Afghanistan, China stands ready to continue to work with all parties, including UNAMA, to promote peace, development and lasting security and stability in Afghanistan.

Mr. Alfaro de Alba (Panama) (*spoke in Spanish*): Mr. President, we welcome your participation, as you preside over this meeting today.

Let me begin by thanking Special Representative Roza Otunbayeva for her presentation of the relevant report (S/2025/554), for her unwavering commitment and for her leadership at the helm of the United Nations Assistance Mission in Afghanistan. We wish her every success in her next steps.

We also welcome Ms. Hanifa Girowal, whose courageous work for Afghan women's rights deserves our full respect and recognition. We acknowledge the participation of the representatives of the countries accompanying us and distinguishing us today.

Panama wishes to begin by expressing its condolences to the victims of the devastating earthquake that struck eastern Afghanistan at the end of August. This

tragedy, which has claimed the lives of thousands of people, further aggravates the already alarming humanitarian crisis in the country and underlines the urgency of strengthening funding and access to assistance.

The restrictions imposed on women and girls in Afghanistan continue to represent one of the most serious violations of human dignity of our time. Prohibitions that limit their presence in public life and their access to education and the media violate fundamental rights, reflect a deliberate policy of repression and weaken the very fabric of society. To deny girls access to knowledge is to disconnect a generation from its future. Professional women in sectors such as health, education and the media are essential for social cohesion. Restricting their participation impoverishes debate, limits development and deprives millions of Afghans of key role models. A society that blocks knowledge forgoes progress.

The lack of a clear and functional legal framework remains a serious obstacle to governance, the fulfilment of the country's international obligations and the protection of the most basic rights. Structural challenges to human security persist in various regions, and we note with concern the growing use of autonomous technologies, which, as in other parts of the world, have direct consequences for the civilian population. In addition, attacks on United Nations personnel and violent incidents in areas of return require immediate responses. We call on the Taliban to take concrete steps to identify those responsible, prevent further incidents and ensure the safety of those who are still working for the well-being of the Afghan people.

The situation of returnees has become a silent crisis, with cumulative impacts on the country's institutional, social and economic capacities. Recent United Nations reports clearly document the physical, legal and social risks faced by returnees, often without preparation, without support and without the minimum conditions for reintegration. Millions return to a reality marked by a lack of employment, a shortage of basic services and weak protection systems. The impact on already vulnerable host communities is profound. The return of families expelled by other States, without prior notice, cannot be considered a voluntary process of return: on the contrary, it is a form of revictimization. Afghan children, in particular, face an alarming situation. Children who return without protection networks are more susceptible to radicalization, exploitation and exclusion. In this context, we value the work of the Office of the United Nations High Commissioner for Refugees, whose role has been essential in the protection of returnees and the strengthening of host communities. Its work should be strengthened, not restricted.

At the structural level, the Gender Index, launched recently by UN-Women, ranks Afghanistan among the most unequal countries in the world. This gap affects all aspects of daily life, from access to food to the possibility of exercising a profession. Faced with this reality, it is important to recognize the efforts of the United Nations system. Programmes led by the United Nations Development Programme are generating sustainable livelihoods and strengthening the resilience of highly affected communities.

The most recent meetings under the Doha process, convened by the United Nations on 30 June and 1 July 2025, confirm that there is still a window of opportunity to move towards a viable political solution that cannot be missed. But for it to be legitimate, it must be truly inclusive, and women, youth and the most affected communities must be part of any lasting political solution that emerges. This inclusion cannot be limited to the negotiating table but must translate into concrete improvements in people's lives.

Food insecurity remains a cause for major alarm. Hunger cannot, in any context, be used as an instrument of control. In this or any other scenario in which access to food is blocked, an injustice is committed that transcends borders and that must not be

normalized by the international community. We therefore urge the Taliban to lift all barriers preventing humanitarian access to communities by United Nations personnel. The continued presence of the United Nations in the country is in itself a vote of confidence. Blocking its work means rejecting this international support.

Finally, we reiterate that without political will or concrete confidence-building measures, there is no possible path towards a lasting solution. Cooperation calls for commitments, and commitments are sustained through action. An effective response must be based on principles and must be impartial and available to all Afghans. The people of Afghanistan deserve better. We, as the international community, have a duty to demand what is reasonable, defend what is just and act without delay.

Mr. Ahmad (Pakistan): It is a pleasure, Mr. President, to see you preside over the Council. We commend the Korean delegation for its skilful leadership of the Council this month.

We take note of the Secretary-General's report (S/2025/554) and thank Ms. Roza Otunbayeva, Special Representative of the Secretary-General for Afghanistan, for her comprehensive briefing. We value the efforts made by the United Nations Assistance Mission in Afghanistan (UNAMA) to promote normalization in Afghanistan under very difficult circumstances. We have also listened to the statement made by Ms. Hanifa Girowal, and we agree that, without a doubt, the equal participation of women is essential for national development and reconciliation in Afghanistan.

Let me also express Pakistan's deepest condolences to the people of Afghanistan for last month's devastating earthquake in the East, which claimed more than 1,400 lives and injured thousands. Pakistan has provided 105 tons of humanitarian assistance to help the families affected by this tragedy. The Taliban have now been in power for more than four years. While civil war has ended for the first time in four decades, Afghanistan's situation remains deeply worrying. Sanctions, a collapsed banking system, inadequate humanitarian aid, poverty, terrorism, narcotics and human rights concerns continue to define Afghanistan's landscape.

These challenges stem not only from Taliban policies and the country's turbulent history, but also from shifting global priorities, the lack of unity and the slow response of the international community. The 2025 humanitarian needs and response plan, for example, has received only 27 per cent of the required $2.42 billion. The international community must close this gap and ease the suffering of ordinary Afghans caught in a political impasse and divergent policies. It is important to ensure that the Taliban sanctions regime does not fall prey to the political considerations of Council members. Travel ban exemption requests remain crucial for meaningful engagement and must be examined in an objective manner, consistent with the objectives of the Council, and with sensitivity for the genuine concerns of Afghanistan's immediate neighbours.

Stabilizing Afghanistan's economy, reviving its banking system and creating realistic pathways for unfreezing its financial assets are essential. Preventing poppy cultivation also remains important, with the support of United Nations-led initiatives promoting alternative livelihoods. Despite security concerns, Pakistan has engaged the Afghan interim Government at a high level to enhance cooperation, security, trade, counter-narcotics efforts and regional connectivity initiatives, such as the trans-Afghanistan railway project. We support the various regional forums for fostering engagement. Deputy Prime Minister and Minister for Foreign Affairs, Senator Mohammad Ishaq Dar, visited Kabul and participated in successful trilateral dialogues at the level of Ministers for Foreign Affairs with Afghanistan, Uzbekistan and China. Likewise, we held a quadrilateral meeting of special representatives for Afghanistan from Pakistan, China, Iran and Russia, in Dushanbe, where we agreed on result-oriented engagement with the Afghan interim authorities.

Pakistan has consistently advocated sustained engagement with Afghanistan and was among the first to propose a road map for normalization. We look forward to the next steps of the United Nations-led Doha process and plan of action for its mosaic approach, which must address Afghanistan's multifaceted challenges in a balanced and comprehensive manner, as was also recommended by the independent assessment report.

For over four decades, Pakistan has welcomed with open arms millions of Afghan refugees, despite our limitations and inadequate international assistance. No country has single-handedly demonstrated that level of commitment in hosting refugees in such large numbers and for such long durations, other than Pakistan. It was understood that these were not indefinite stays. Besides, Pakistan has had to cope with huge numbers and caseloads of illegal foreigners, including Afghans without legal status or documents, which also poses a serious security threat to Pakistan.

With conflict now having ended, many Afghans have been repatriated in a dignified, phased and orderly manner. Pakistan has also instituted a liberal visa regime that enables a large number of Afghans to be in Pakistan legally for various purposes, including family links, education, medical care and business. While we will continue to extend all possible assistance to our Afghan brothers and sisters, the international community must shoulder its responsibility and take the necessary steps to ameliorate the conditions and share this burden more equitably. International partners must fulfil their obligations, including with regard to their commitments — which are, in fact, long-delayed and unkept — including for third-country resettlement.

The Taliban authorities must also fulfil their international counter-terrorism obligations. Terrorism emanating from Afghanistan remains the gravest threat to Pakistan's national security. Terrorist entities, including the Islamic State in Iraq and the Levant-Khorasan, Al-Qaida, Tehrik-e Taliban Pakistan (TTP), the Eastern Turkistan Islamic Movement and the Balochistan Liberation Army (BLA) and its Majeed Brigade, operate from Afghan sanctuaries, with more than 60 such terrorist camps serving as hubs for enabling cross-border infiltration and attacks. We have credible evidence of collaboration among these terrorist groups through joint training, illicit weapons trading, the provision of refuge to terrorists and coordinated attacks, all aimed at targeting civilians and law enforcement agencies and disrupting and sabotaging infrastructure and development projects in Pakistan. We also need to zoom in on the interlinkages playing out on the digital landscape. Their propaganda networks — nearly 70 social media accounts traced to Afghan Internet protocol addresses — must also be curbed. That requires full support and cooperation from social media platform providers with governments.

Pakistan and China have jointly submitted to the Committee pursuant to resolutions 1267 (1999), 1989 (2011) and 2253 (2015) concerning Islamic State in Iraq and the Levant (Da'esh), Al-Qaida and associated individuals, groups, undertakings and entities a request to designate the BLA and its Majeed Brigade as terrorist organizations. We hope the Council will act swiftly on this listing in order to curb their terrorist activities. The TTP, with nearly 6,000 fighters, remains the largest United Nations-designated terrorist group on Afghan soil. Pakistan has successfully thwarted multiple infiltration attempts by TTP and BLA terrorists from across Afghanistan, confiscating significant caches of sophisticated, military-grade, modern equipment left behind by international forces in Afghanistan.

These efforts come at a heavy price, with huge sacrifices by our valiant security forces and civilians. Just this month, 12 Pakistani soldiers were martyred in a single incident while defending the border areas. This situation is intolerable. UNAMA must strengthen efforts, as mandated, to prevent the illicit trade and destabilizing

accumulation of small arms and light weapons and their diversion in Afghanistan and the region.

The Taliban must also meet their other international obligations. The continued restrictions on women and girls are inconsistent with Islamic traditions and the norms of Muslim society. Pakistan supports international engagement with Afghanistan, with clear objectives, reciprocal steps and a realistic road map, guided by dialogue and diplomacy, for that is the only viable pathway to lasting peace in Afghanistan. Isolation and disengagement serve no one's interests.

As immediate neighbours, bound by geography, culture and history, no country desires peace and stability in Afghanistan more than Pakistan, and no country has suffered from the consequences of decades of conflict in Afghanistan more than Pakistan. We therefore remain committed to supporting a peaceful, prosperous Afghanistan for the sake of our region and in the best interests of the world.

Ms. Landi (Denmark): I would like to thank Special Representative Otunbayeva for her briefing and her service to the people of Afghanistan as we approach the end of her mandate. I thank Ms. Girowal, for her leadership. Denmark stands with her in her fight for an Afghanistan where all women and girls can live in dignity and equality. Her messages were devastating, but they were important to hear, so we thank her.

Allow me to raise three points.

First, let me convey Denmark's deepest condolences to those affected by the devastating earthquake that struck eastern Afghanistan on 31 August. The earthquake struck at a time of crisis, exacerbating already existing protection challenges, including a dire humanitarian situation. As we have heard, entire communities remain displaced, food insecurity is rising, and critical health services are either overwhelmed or non-existent. Sadly, even on an issue as fundamental as life-saving assistance, the Taliban's discriminatory policies are directly undermining the humanitarian response. At a time when medical assistance is needed more than ever, the Taliban has decided to uphold its ban on Afghan women working for non-governmental organizations and United Nations agencies and its ban on women pursuing medical education. To put it bluntly, not only are women banned from becoming doctors, but male doctors are banned from treating female patients.

We strongly call on the Taliban to facilitate unhindered humanitarian access to those in need, in accordance with the humanitarian principles of humanity, neutrality, impartiality and independence, and to abide by their obligations under international law. Women and girls who are in a particularly precarious situation must be prioritized in this response. Even under these extremely challenging circumstances, the United Nations and its humanitarian partners continue to deliver. They need our continued support. As an international community, we must step up and scale up funding for the humanitarian needs and response plan and, importantly, for the Afghan people.

Secondly, Denmark remains gravely concerned by the continued deterioration of the human rights situation in Afghanistan. Nowhere is this more visible than in the systematic exclusion and erasure of women and girls from Afghan life. The Taliban-controlled judiciary continues to restrict Afghans' access to justice and protection, cementing its system of discrimination and oppression. Regrettably, the Taliban has shown no sign or willingness to ease restrictions. In fact, not one has been reversed since they violently took control of the country four years ago. Instead, they have continued to relentlessly expand their restrictive policies. The enforcement of the law on vice and virtue is a clear and damning example. The Taliban must immediately allow women to pursue higher education and work in all sectors and ensure their full, equal, meaningful and safe participation in society.

As a Council, we must be firm. We cannot allow the most severe women's rights crisis in the world to become normalized. We cannot turn a blind eye as half of the country's population is systematically and cruelly erased. We must insist, resolutely and collectively, that the Taliban uphold Afghanistan's international obligations and that they reverse all discriminatory policies. All those responsible for gross human rights violations and serious violations of international humanitarian law must be held accountable. We note in this regard the recent International Criminal Court arrest warrants against two Taliban leaders and the ongoing efforts under the Human Rights Council.

Thirdly, Denmark continues to support the Doha process as the framework for principled international engagement. We welcome efforts by the United Nations Assistance Mission in Afghanistan to develop a political road map and underline the importance of inclusive dialogue, including with Afghan women, civil society and representatives of diverse ethnic and religious communities. The Doha process must stay anchored in the recommendations of the United Nations Special Coordinator and follow a clear step-by-step, conditions-based approach. Engagement on the Taliban's priorities can only advance if there is reciprocity on their part. We must demand this progress in deeds, not just words.

Afghanistan's people deserve a future marked not by despair and exclusion, but by dignity, opportunity and hope, especially for its women and girls. Denmark remains unwavering in its support to upholding the rights and aspirations of all Afghans, and we look forward to working with all Council members to this end.

Mrs. Blokar Drobič (Slovenia): I would like to thank Special Representative of the Secretary-General Otunbayeva for her briefing today and for her work and contributions during her tenure. I also wish to thank Ms. Girowal for her messages, her requests and her statement.

Let me first extend our deepest sympathy and condolences to those affected by the earthquake in eastern Afghanistan on 31 August. Such natural disasters, compounded by adverse effects of climate change and environmental degradation, underscore the urgent need for disaster risk reduction and for strengthening early detection and rapid response. The resulting impact on an already dire humanitarian situation and fragile socioeconomic situation in Afghanistan should be addressed. We emphasize the importance of ensuring safe, timely and effective access to life-saving assistance for all those in need, without any form of discrimination or hindrance.

The overall situation in Afghanistan remains dire and deeply concerning. The interlinked risks associated with poverty and extremism, whether manifested through terrorism or the Taliban's repressive policies, further threaten to isolate the country. The Taliban's persistent restrictive policies and practices continue to severely affect the economic, social and personal lives of Afghans, in particular women, girls and members of minority groups. Socioeconomic exclusion of more than half of the Afghan population undermines the scope and capacities of Afghanistan's economic growth and development. It exacerbates security risks and contributes to instability. These measures also carry serious ramifications for the Afghan returnees.

This is the third year since the ban on girls' secondary and higher education. It is the third year of lost opportunities for the future. Education is not a waste of time or resources. It is a fundamental right, including for Afghan girls. It brings a promising future for them individually and lays the foundation for a more stable, inclusive and prosperous society as a whole. Therefore, education is the most profitable investment. We continue to call for this ban on education to be immediately reversed, together with all other discriminatory measures targeting women.

In this context, we are deeply concerned about United Nations reports about the suspension of women's activities due to the Taliban's restrictions on Afghan female

staff. We join the United Nations Assistance Mission in Afghanistan in calling for the immediate lifting of these restrictions to ensure the continuation of critical humanitarian support. The lack of progress on this issue, despite previous engagement efforts, coupled with the overall deterioration of the human rights situation, will inevitably affect the future course of action of the international community. While we continue to support a comprehensive and inclusive so-called "mosaic approach", we must express our disappointment with the insufficient progress achieved thus far.

The path to sustainable peace is paved with justice. No form of development can bring genuine social prosperity and ensure the full enjoyment of human rights if justice is not rendered. Lasting peace requires societies to heal, rebuild and establish trust between people and institutions. The cycle of impunity must be broken. Impunity, including for grave breaches of international law, only perpetrates further suffering. In this regard, the International Criminal Court is playing a pivotal role at the international level in ensuring accountability for the most serious crimes. Slovenia welcomes the recent developments regarding arrest warrants for the Taliban leadership. They mark a milestone in seeking justice for serious violations and abuses against Afghan women and girls. Slovenia fully supports the continued investigations by the Prosecutor. No one is above the law.

Mrs. Balta (Greece): I would like to thank Special Representative Roza Otunbayeva for her remarks and for her tireless work in Afghanistan for the past three years. I would also like to thank Ms. Hanifa Girowal for her sobering briefing but also for her dedication and leadership.

Four years after seizing control of Afghanistan, the Taliban remain unwilling to cooperate with the international community and honour their international obligations. Afghan women — half of the country's population — are effectively erased from public life. The "Gender Index 2024: Afghanistan", published by UN-Women in June, is revealing, as is the Secretary-General's latest report on conflict-related sexual violence (S/2025/389). The segregation of women in public spaces, the enforcement of strict dress codes and the requirement for a male guardian are only some aspects of the Law on the Propagation of Virtue and Prevention of Vice that are utterly unacceptable. In view of the above, I would like to make the following three points.

First, Greece strongly condemns the violations and abuses of human rights and fundamental freedoms of all Afghans, in particular women and girls, and calls upon the Taliban to immediately reverse all restrictive policies and practices and comply with their international obligations. A stricter implementation of sharia law and the belief that it can replace a democratic constitution are very concerning. Equally alarming are the shrinking of civic space, the backlash against peaceful protests and the restrictions on media freedom and freedom of expression through the regulation of the use of smartphones, social media and the conduct of political debates.

Secondly, despite the country's modest economic growth, the humanitarian situation remains deeply worrisome. Food insecurity has reached unprecedented levels, with 9.5 million people facing crisis or emergency conditions. At the same time, natural disasters such as the earthquakes that recently struck the country are further exacerbating the already dire situation on the ground. Greece expresses its condolences to the people of Afghanistan and the families of the victims and its gratitude to all the organizations of the United Nations system that are working tirelessly to provide life-saving assistance.

Thirdly, I would like to reiterate Greece's full support for the United Nations Assistance Mission in Afghanistan and its proposed road map for fostering a more coherent, coordinated and structured engagement between the international community and the Taliban. The meetings of the two working groups on counter-narcotics and the private sector on 30 June and 1 July are developments in the right

direction. We also commend the focus of discussions on female entrepreneurship and we call for a furthering of the full, equal, meaningful and safe participation of Afghan women in the process and the inclusion of all segments of Afghan society.

Greece strongly believes in the resilience of the Afghan people and in the country's potential to reintegrate into the international community. For this to happen, however, the Taliban must uphold their international obligations in full, respect human rights, restore women to their rightful place in society, establish an inclusive Government and counter terrorism.

The President: I shall now make a statement in my capacity as the representative of the Republic of Korea.

At the outset, I would like to express my appreciation to the briefers today for their insightful presentations. Special thanks from me and, indeed, from the Government of the Republic of Korea go to Special Representative of the Secretary-General Roza Otunbayeva for her dedicated service over the past three years.

I reiterate our sympathy and condolences to all those affected by the recent severe earthquake in eastern Afghanistan.

There are three points to make regarding what to do with respect to Afghanistan in the context of the Security Council's deliberations on the matter.

First, it should be noted that the country's integration or reintegration into the international community — an end that we are all pursuing — cannot materialize if the world's requests to the Taliban in the form of Security Council decisions remain unheeded. Respect for human rights, in particular those of women and girls, is a prerequisite for any earnest, corresponding measures on the part of members of the international community. A series of regressive measures in the country have been undermining the readiness and willingness of others to be forthcoming and helpful, while also weakening the domestic support base in this regard. On top of the human rights front, terrorism, among other challenges, continues to warrant due vigilance.

Secondly, we recognize and fully support the role of the United Nations Assistance Mission in Afghanistan (UNAMA) in fulfilling the mandates that the Council has given it. At the same time and without prejudice to the ongoing reform efforts in the United Nations machinery, it is crucial that UNAMA operate in close cooperation with, and under the political guidance of, United Nations Headquarters so that its activities can yield as many meaningful outcomes as possible in the face of this situation. Equally, effective coordination with other relevant parts of the United Nations system is important to ensure a unified United Nations approach towards Afghanistan. We hope that the Secretary-General and the incoming Special Representative of the Secretary-General will pay full attention to this aspect.

Thirdly and lastly, given the unmatched complexity of the issue of Afghanistan, comprehensive prescriptions must accordingly be sought. While the Council remains the very organ with the primary responsibility for the maintenance of international peace and security, it is not a panacea, by design or in practice, having a better chance of working properly through close collaboration with other key international forums. The Doha process, if not noticeably effective, has been very useful, at least in keeping channels of communication open and bringing a glimmer of hope for the future. Regionally motivated forums are essential but should work in such a way as to complement endeavours and promote progress in a broader perspective.

I now resume my functions as President of the Council.

The representative of the United States of America has asked for the floor to make a further statement.

Mr. Kelley (United States of America): I would just respond to the remarks of some members. In our view, generally, matters discussed within the Committee should stay there, in the Committee. But I also want to underscore the responsibility of the Council to ensure that travel ban exemptions are carefully scrutinized.

The President: I now give the floor to the representative of Afghanistan.

Mr. Faiq (Afghanistan): I thank you, Mr. President, for traveling to New York, and we thank your Mission for its able leadership of the Council for this month. We also thank the Secretary-General for his report (S/2025/554), the Special Representative of the Secretary-General, Ms. Roza Otunbayeva, for her briefing and Ms. Hanifa Girowal for her powerful remarks.

We warmly welcome this morning's joint statement by Council members who are signatories of the statement of shared commitments for the principles of women and peace and security. Their unified stance reaffirms an unshakable commitment to defending the rights and dignity of Afghan women and girls and sends a vital message of solidarity at this critical moment.

We are also thankful to all those Council members who expressed their condolences to the people of Afghanistan, and we are grateful to the Secretary-General, Member States and humanitarian partners for their swift response to the recent earthquake in eastern Afghanistan, which took the lives of more than 3,000 people and caused destruction. I also join the call of the Special Representative of the Secretary-General urging countries to continue their critical and emergency support for the people of Afghanistan, particularly for the people affected by this tragedy.

Four years after the Taliban's forced takeover, Afghanistan remains one of the gravest crises before the Council. Despite claims of calm, the reality is stark: deepening repression, humanitarian collapse, political deadlock and a generation at risk of being erased, in a country already crippled by human-made and natural disasters.

Politically, the Taliban continue to consolidate power. Last month, marking their return to Kabul, the Taliban leader ordered the removal of the word "Acting" from officials' titles, signalling a bid for permanent rule without legitimacy. Power is concentrated in the hands of male loyalists from one extremist group. There is no constitution, no inclusive governance, no credible path to reconciliation and no consent of the governed. Instead, an unelected and unaccountable group, having taken a country hostage, issues decrees that distort Islamic values and Afghan culture, while denying the people their right to shape their own future. This is the systematic dismantling of a nation's political identity.

Civic space is vanishing. Restrictions now target political discourse, media, poetry, cultural gatherings and even funeral prayers. Civil society faces surveillance and harassment. Young people, stripped of hope, endure growing mental health crises. Forced displacement and targeted attacks on ethnic and religious minorities persist, particularly against the Hazara communities. And the suppression by the Taliban continues to target all Afghans who do not share their ideologies. At least 60 women were arbitrarily arrested this summer. Increasing security incidents and the presence of terrorist groups further endanger regional stability and national security.

First, the plight of Afghan women and girls is unprecedented. Exactly four years ago today, the Taliban banned secondary education for girls, in the beginning of a campaign to erase women from public life. Universities remain closed, employment opportunities are stripped away, and even humanitarian agencies face pressure to limit female staff. The Taliban went so far as to ban Afghan women from working with the United Nations and international non-governmental organizations (NGOs), an attack not only on women's rights but on the humanitarian lifeline for millions. Women once serving as doctors, teachers, engineers and entrepreneurs are being forced into

invisibility. The result is both a human rights catastrophe and an economic disaster that is crippling Afghanistan's recovery. Female-headed households face extreme hardship, while the psychological toll on women and girls stripped of rights and dreams is immeasurable. This systematic exclusion is nothing less than gender apartheid. We therefore strongly welcome the International Criminal Court's recent decision to issue arrest warrants for Taliban leaders for crimes against humanity. It underscores the gravity of their violations and affirms that impunity must not be tolerated.

Secondly, Afghanistan faces a humanitarian emergency of immense proportions. More than 2 million Afghans have been forcibly returned from neighbouring countries under unsafe conditions this year. They join nearly 23 million in need of assistance, while the humanitarian response plan remains less than one third funded. Food, health and education systems are collapsing. The Taliban continue to obstruct aid, impose discriminatory restrictions and divert resources for political and military purposes. It was reported in the recent report of the Special Inspector General for Afghanistan Reconstruction that the Taliban even influenced, through their bribery, some of the international NGOs or aid organizations. The earthquake in eastern Afghanistan further highlighted how bans on women's participation in aid delivery directly endanger lives.

Thirdly, the security situation remains fragile. The latest report of the Analytical Support and Sanctions Monitoring Team (see S/2024/499) confirms that the Taliban provide a permissive environment for terrorist groups, including Islamic State in Iraq and the Levant-Khorasan, Al-Qaida, their affiliates and foreign terrorist fighters, who operate training camps, conduct cross-border attacks and access advanced weaponry, threatening both regional and global security. Equally troubling are threats and intimidation against United Nations personnel, including female staff, which directly undermine United Nations operations. Meanwhile, the Taliban have banned fibre-optic Internet and Wi-Fi in five provinces, blocking online education, while removing 51 school subjects and eliminating 18 university courses. They proudly report creating nearly 23,000 Islamic education centres, or madrasas, in three years, in which 300,000 children are enrolled. This trajectory is deeply concerning and fosters radicalization, suppresses knowledge and risks causing the intellectual collapse of Afghanistan's future generations.

Fourthly, civic space is shrinking further. Peaceful protests are crushed with lethal force, as was the case in Badakhshan, where farmers resisting poppy eradication were killed. On 16 September, retirees, including women, gathered in Kabul to demand long-withheld pensions. Instead of paying what was owed, the Taliban dissolved the pension system and tied disbursements to religious rulings, leaving thousands destitute.

The United Nations Assistance Mission in Afghanistan has documented grave abuses against Afghans forcibly returned from abroad. Women, girls and former officials and security forces face arbitrary detention, torture and persecution despite so-called amnesties. Walid Naimi, a former security officer returned from Iran, was found tortured and killed after disappearing for 15 days. Civil society activist Ahmad Mujtaba Mohammadi remains in Taliban custody. The report of the Secretary-General confirms that 29,500 people are now held in Taliban prisons, the highest number since 2021. These practices flagrantly violate international law and the principles of non-refoulement. The Taliban's actions constitute gross human rights violations and crimes against humanity. We urge all States to halt forced returns, expand protection pathways and uphold the rights of those fleeing persecution.

The people of Afghanistan and the international community need a government that is reliable, accountable and legitimate, grounded in the rule of law, justice and the will of the people, and respectful of its international obligations. This can

be achieved only through a genuine political process that restores inclusivity and protects the rights of all Afghans.

The Afghan people demand nothing less than self-determination, representation and dignity. They deserve a government chosen by the people, not imposed by force.

Therefore, the Council must send a clear and united message. First, the rights of Afghan women and girls are non-negotiable. No authority can claim legitimacy while excluding women and the majority of Afghans. Secondly, humanitarian assistance must remain principled, impartial, unconditional and without hindrance, ensuring that aid reaches people in need without obstacles, discrimination or diversion. Thirdly, engagement with the Taliban must be principled and conditional. Fourthly, the Council must demand an end to gender apartheid and support strong investigative, monitoring and reporting mechanisms to hold the Taliban accountable under international law for crimes against humanity. Fifthly, Afghanistan must be prevented from once again becoming a sanctuary for terrorism through robust monitoring, targeted sanctions and regional cooperation. Sixthly, the Council must support a credible political process, under United Nations leadership, with the participation of all credible Afghan representatives, including women and girls and youth, aimed at restoring an inclusive, representative, constitutional order.

The Afghan people have not given up. Inside the country, brave women, journalists, activists, ordinary citizens and resistance movements continue to oppose oppression. In the diaspora, Afghans tirelessly advocate for freedom and justice. What they ask of the Council is simple. Do not abandon Afghanistan to tyranny. Do not normalize an extremist regime that oppresses half its population and threatens international peace and security. Do not allow the suffering of millions to fade into silence.

We remain thankful to all international partners who, over the past four years, have supported the people of Afghanistan, especially women and girls, in their pursuit of a free, inclusive and sovereign Afghanistan.

Afghanistan stands at a crossroads between perpetual repression and the possibility of a democratic, inclusive and peaceful future. The Council has the power and the responsibility to help to ensure that the path chosen is one of justice, dignity and hope.

The President: I now give the floor to the representative of Kyrgyzstan.

Mrs. Kasymalieva (Kyrgyzstan): We would like to express our appreciation to the President of the Security Council, the Republic of Korea, for convening this important meeting, and to the briefers, especially the Special Representative of the Secretary-General for Afghanistan, Ms. Roza Otunbayeva, for their valuable insights.

At the outset, allow me to convey our heartfelt condolences to the people of Afghanistan in connection with the recent devastating earthquake that resulted in numerous casualties and widespread destruction. We extend our deepest sympathy to the families of the victims and wish a swift and full recovery to all those affected.

The Kyrgyz Republic remains committed to fostering good-neighbourly relations and is deeply interested in a peaceful, stable and prosperous Afghanistan. We highlight the efforts made by the current Government of Afghanistan on the security situation, on addressing the threat of terrorism and on reducing opium poppy cultivation and narcotics production. These are important steps towards long-term peace and regional stability. We underscore the importance of strengthening bilateral collaboration, particularly in the spheres of trade, investment, transport, energy and overall economic development.

Let me underline a few points.

In support of Afghanistan's recovery, Kyrgyzstan is actively contributing to humanitarian and economic assistance. On the instructions of the President of the Kyrgyz Republic, Sadyr Zhaparov, in September 2024, the Kyrgyz Republic delivered further humanitarian aid to Afghanistan, consisting of food products. We advocate the timely implementation of key regional initiatives, especially the Central Asia South Asia Electricity Transmission and Trade Project, in order to connect Central and South Asian energy systems through Afghanistan. Regional connectivity remains a priority. We highlight the signing of the memorandum of cooperation in July 2023 in Lanzhou, China, between the railway authorities of the participating countries. The aim is to advance the development of the China–Kyrgyzstan–Uzbekistan–Afghanistan transport corridor.

We are also pleased with the successful business forum and business-to-business meetings held in Kabul in January 2024, which brought together representatives of the Kyrgyz and Afghan business communities. Kyrgyz companies are currently operating in Afghanistan in sectors such as mining, telecommunications, pharmacy and services. We are preparing to inaugurate the Kyrgyz Trade House in Kabul as a further step to strengthen economic ties.

In 2025, Kyrgyzstan will continue to provide humanitarian assistance to the Afghan people, including food and medical aid. Additionally, in response to a formal request from the Afghan side, and with a view to supporting institutional development, Kyrgyzstan is preparing to deploy a team of experts and technical specialists to Kabul across various sectors. This initiative is aimed at contributing to the professional development and capacity-building of Afghan civil servants.

Kyrgyzstan remains a steadfast partner in the collective efforts to ensure stability, recovery and sustainable development in Afghanistan. We stand ready to engage constructively with regional and international stakeholders towards this common goal.

The President: I now give the floor to the representative of the Islamic Republic of Iran.

Mr. Iravani (Islamic Republic of Iran): We thank the Special Representative of the Secretary-General for Afghanistan, Ms. Roza Otunbayeva, for her invaluable briefing. We listened carefully to the statement delivered by Ms. Hanifa Girowal.

The Islamic Republic of Iran expresses its profound sympathy and solidarity with the people and authorities of Afghanistan following the recent devastating earthquake, which tragically claimed numerous lives. In this regard, Iran has promptly extended humanitarian assistance to support the affected population and stands ready to continue assisting Afghanistan in overcoming the consequences of this tragedy.

We take note of the latest report of the Secretary-General, which provides an update on the situation in Afghanistan, including the political and humanitarian activities of the United Nations (S/2025/554). In the light of the report, I wish to highlight the following points.

First, as Afghanistan's immediate neighbour, sharing more than 900 km of common border and having hosted millions of Afghan refugees for decades, Iran considers peace, stability and development in Afghanistan as directly linked to its own national security and to the stability of the wider region. To this end, Iran remains actively engaged with Afghanistan's de facto authorities through both bilateral and regional initiatives. We have also been constructively involved in the Doha process under the auspices of the United Nations and have played an active role in its working groups.

Secondly, Afghanistan's future must be Afghan-led and Afghan-owned. A lasting solution can emerge only through an inclusive political process that reflects the country's ethnic and political diversity, respects its sovereignty and guarantees the rights of all Afghans, particularly women and girls. Any externally imposed solution is neither viable nor sustainable.

Thirdly, the de facto authorities are a reality on the ground, and the international community has no choice but to engage with them. Constructive, practical engagement is essential to address the ongoing humanitarian and economic crises that continue to threaten regional stability. In this regard, we stress that humanitarian assistance must never be politicized. Sanctions should not be used as political leverage to obstruct economic stabilization or engagement with the de facto authorities. Afghan assets frozen abroad should be released unconditionally to serve the Afghan people. Likewise, the travel ban exemption mechanism for designated Taliban individuals must not be politicized or exploited by Council members for narrow political interests. Its full restoration is essential, as it remains a vital tool for fostering dialogue and advancing a comprehensive constructive approach to the situation in Afghanistan.

Fourthly, Iran has borne a disproportionate burden for decades, hosting millions of Afghan refugees and migrants, often with insufficient international support. This humanitarian responsibility has imposed significant costs on our society, placing a severe strain on resources and infrastructure and creating complex security and cross-border challenges. In the wake of Israeli aggression against Iran, these pressures have intensified further. Iran cannot continue to shoulder this responsibility alone and has therefore had no choice but to return illegal Afghan residents to their homeland. It is important to note that Iran has been actively engaged with the Afghan authorities throughout the return process to ensure that the conditions for safe and dignified return are met.

Iran strongly supports the emergence of Afghanistan as an independent, united and peaceful State, free from terrorism, conflict and narcotics. We affirm our steadfast commitment to a stable and self-reliant Afghanistan and will continue to work closely with regional and international partners towards this objective. Afghanistan must be assisted in adopting comprehensive measures to eradicate terrorism, dismantle all terrorist groups without exception and prevent the use of its territory against any neighbours, the region and beyond.

Finally, the United Nations Assistance Mission in Afghanistan plays a crucial role in addressing Afghanistan's challenges, and we reaffirm our support for the Mission's mandate and its effective implementation.

The President: I now give the floor to the representative of India.

Mr. Parvathaneni (India): I thank you for convening today's meeting. I thank Ms. Roza Otunbayeva, Special Representative of the Secretary-General for Afghanistan and Head of the United Nations Assistance Mission in Afghanistan (UNAMA), for her briefing. As it is her last briefing in this capacity, I should like to place on record my delegation's sincere appreciation to her for leading that Mission with distinction. We value her close cooperation, which we hope to carry forward with UNAMA in future. Our delegation also notes the comments made by Ms. Hanifa Girowal.

India and Afghanistan share a civilizational relationship, being contiguous neighbours. Our bonds of friendship span many centuries, and this history inspires us to foster closer engagement with the Afghan people. India has a paramount interest in ensuring peace and stability in Afghanistan. We believe in the utmost importance of international and regional consensus and cooperation on key issues concerning Afghanistan and actively engage with all relevant parties to promote peace, stability

and development in the country. Our participation in United Nations meetings in Doha and other regional forums reflects our efforts.

India's immediate priorities in Afghanistan include the provision of humanitarian assistance and implementation of capacity-building initiatives for the Afghan people. India's commitment to Afghanistan's reconstruction is demonstrated through more than 500 development partnership projects across all provinces. Our work with United Nations agencies in critical areas such as health, food security, education and sports is also a manifestation of this goal.

In the aftermath of the earthquake earlier this month, India was among the first countries to provide humanitarian assistance. We immediately delivered 1,000 family tents and 15 tons of food supplies to the affected provinces of Afghanistan. An additional 21 tons of relief materials, including essential medicines, hygiene kits, blankets and generators, were dispatched. More relief supplies are on the way and will be delivered in the coming days.

This humanitarian assistance dovetails with the support provided by India since August 2021, which has included approximately 50,000 tons of wheat, over 330 tons of medicines and vaccinations, 40,000 litres of pesticides, as well as other essential social support items for millions of Afghans in dire need of humanitarian assistance. In partnership with the United Nations Office on Drugs and Crime, we have provided 84 metric tons of assistance in medicines, and 32 metric tons of social support items for drug rehabilitation programmes, particularly those focused on women. India's undergraduate and postgraduate scholarships and fellowships for Afghan students since 2023 total over 2,000, including nearly 600 for girls and women.

India is closely monitoring the security situation in Afghanistan. The international community must coordinate efforts towards ensuring that entities and individuals designated by the Security Council — in particular Islamic State in Iraq and the Levant, Al-Qaida and their affiliates, including Lashkar-e-Tayyiba and Jaish-i-Mohammed, along with those who facilitate their operations — no longer exploit Afghan territory for terrorist activities. On the political front, India's Minister for External Affairs has spoken twice with the acting Minister for Foreign Affairs of Afghanistan. We welcome the strong condemnation by the Afghan side of the 22 April Pahalgam terrorist attack.

Any coherent policy to address a post-conflict situation must combine incentivizing positive behaviour and disincentivizing harmful actions. Focusing only on punitive measures is unlikely to achieve the desired results. The United Nations and the international community have adopted more nuanced approaches in other post-conflict contexts. Afghanistan needs a fresh approach, with hitherto unused policy instruments, to support its people, who are in such dire need. A business-as-usual approach can only be expected to maintain the status quo, which is not good for Afghanistan and is unlikely to meet the expectations of the international community for the people of Afghanistan.

In more than four years of living under a sanctions regime, the Afghan people have not seen much scope for enhanced development assistance and cooperation. The rather unfortunate earthquake has made the situation even more dire. This is a time for compassion, a time for lending a helping hand to millions of Afghans suffering under the yoke of poverty, disease and hunger.

In conclusion, I would like to reiterate that our commitment to meeting the development needs of the people of Afghanistan is non-negotiable. We will continue to engage with all relevant stakeholders and broadly support the international community's efforts towards a stable, peaceful and prosperous Afghanistan.

The meeting rose at 12.50 p.m.